WP-4B-01: Paracetamol administration (oral and IV)

Example General Hospital, Ward 4B. Version 3 (fictional). Owner: Ward 4B nurse in charge (fictional role).

FICTIONAL TRAINING DOCUMENT. Not clinical guidance. Example General Hospital is fictional.

Scope

Adult inpatients on Ward 4B who are prescribed paracetamol by mouth or by intravenous infusion.

Before every dose

- Check every source of paracetamol in the last 24 hours, including combination products and doses given in other departments or before admission.
- Confirm the time of the last dose. The minimum interval between doses is 4 hours.
- Confirm the patient's current weight in MedTrack. Do not estimate it.

Dose limits on Ward 4B

Adults weighing 50 kg or more: 1 g per dose, every 4 to 6 hours, up to a maximum of 4 g in 24 hours.

Adults weighing less than 50 kg, or with hepatic impairment, chronic alcohol use or malnutrition: 15 mg/kg per dose, up to a maximum of 60 mg/kg in 24 hours, and never more than 3 g in 24 hours.

Oral and intravenous doses count together towards the same 24-hour maximum.

Intravenous paracetamol

Infuse over 15 minutes. Check the infusion site before and after the infusion. Switch to oral paracetamol as soon as the patient can swallow, unless the prescriber records a reason not to.

Ward 4B local rules

- Record every dose in MedTrack within 15 minutes of giving it.
- If a dose falls due less than 4 hours after a dose given in another department, hold it and contact the prescriber.
- If the 24-hour total would exceed the limit for the patient, do not give the dose. Record it as held and inform the nurse in charge.

When to escalate

Suspected overdose, or a 24-hour total above the limit for the patient: stop all paracetamol and request an urgent medical review. Do not wait for symptoms.

New jaundice, confusion or abdominal pain in a patient receiving paracetamol: inform the prescriber the same shift.

Patient information

Tell patients that many cold and flu remedies contain paracetamol, and ask them not to take their own supply while on the ward.